
Topic 6: Criminological psychology

Topic overview

Students must show understanding that criminological psychology is about the definition and causes of crime and anti-social behaviour, and of the identification and treatment of offenders undertaken by forensic investigators. Individual differences and developmental psychology must be considered when learning about the possible causes of criminal behaviour, such as labelling, self-fulfilling prophecy and social learning.

Subject content	What students need to learn:
6.1 Content	Explanations of crime and anti-social behaviour, with consideration given to gender differences
	6.1.1 Biological explanations, including brain injury, amygdala and aggression, XYY syndrome and personality.
	6.1.2 Social explanations, including labelling, self-fulfilling prophecy.
	Understanding the offender, offence analysis and case formulation
	6.1.3 Cognitive interview and ethical interview techniques.
	6.1.4 The use of psychological formulation to understand the function of offending behaviour in the individual.
	Two treatments for offenders, including strengths and weaknesses and one study for each that considers their effectiveness
	6.1.5 One cognitive-behavioural treatment e.g. CBT, social skills training, anger management, assertiveness training.
	6.1.6 One biological treatment, e.g. improved diet, hormone treatment.
	6.1.7 Factors influencing eye-witness testimony, including consideration of reliability (including post-event information and weapon focus). Studies can be the same as those used for the methodology section of criminological psychology.
	6.1.8 Factors influencing jury decision-making, including characteristics of the defendant and pre-trial publicity, including studies in this area.

Subject content	What students need to learn:
6.1 Content <i>(continued)</i>	6.1.9 Individual differences • Personality as a factor in criminal/anti-social behaviour. • Individual differences affecting whether a self-fulfilling prophecy occurs, e.g. with regard to developing criminal or anti-social behaviour. 6.1.10 Developmental psychology • The self-fulfilling prophecy is an explanation for criminal/anti-social behaviour that explains development of some individuals. • Social learning theory is a theory of human development that can account for criminal/anti-social behaviour. • Other causes for criminal/anti-social behaviour, including biological, can explain development.